

He then defeated Darius decisively at Issus and Gaugamela and consolidated his victories by marching through the eastern parts of the empire and putting down any military problems he found. Finally, he established the eastern boundary of his empire by defeating Porus at the Battle of the Hydaspes.

Despite these obviously careful strategic moves Alexander has been criticised as a military strategist. His decision to disband his fleet (334BC), his failure to cover Darius' movements at Issus (333BC) and his decision to march across the Gedrosian desert (325BC), which proved disastrous, have been given by many modern historians (such as GL Cawkwell and P Green) as examples of poor strategy (see Source Study, opposite).

Tactical skill

Alexander's ability as a tactician is undoubted. Reread pp147–50. His tactics at each of these engagements show brilliance. His ability to win victories over much larger Persian armies at Issus and Gaugamela and to overcome the problems presented at Tyre and Hydaspes are indications of his talent. As Arrian says:

In arming and equipping troops and in his military dispositions he was always masterly... his ability to seize the moment for a swift blow, before his enemy had any suspicion of what was coming, was beyond praise.

ARRIAN, *THE CAMPAIGNS OF ALEXANDER*, 7.29

Leadership

Morale was another problem faced by Alexander. His ability to get his men successfully through the hardships of an eleven-year campaign can be attributed to his personal leadership. Arrian describes him thus: Noble indeed was his power of inspiring his men, of filling them with confidence, and, in the moment of danger, of sweeping away their fear by the spectacle of his own fearlessness. When risks had to be taken, he took them with the utmost boldness... No cheat or liar caught him off guard, and both his

Question the sources

Read the sources and see if you agree with the criticisms of Alexander's skills as a military strategist by modern historians.

Source 1—Arrian, *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 1.20

Alexander now decided to disband his fleet. He had not, at the moment, the money for maintaining it; he knew that it was no match for the Persian navy, and he had no wish to subject any part of his strength, in ships or men, to the risk of disaster. Moreover, now that his army was master of the continent, he was well aware that a fleet was no longer of any use to him: by seizing the coastal towns he could reduce the Persian navy to impotence, for they would then have no port on the Asian coast which they could use, and no source of replacement for their crews.

Source 2—Plutarch, *Life of Alexander*, 66

Here he endured terrible privations and lost great numbers of men, with the result that he did not bring back from India so much as a quarter of his fighting force... Some of his men died from disease, some of the wretched food, some of the scorching heat, but most from sheer hunger, for they had to march through an uncultivated region whose inhabitants only eked out a wretched existence.

Source 3—Arrian, *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 6.23

From there Alexander marched through Gedrosian territory. The route was a difficult one, and no supplies were to be had; worst of all, in many places there was not even water for the men. They were forced to cover great distances at night, going some way inland, in spite of the fact that Alexander was anxious to work along the coast in order to see what possible anchorages there were and, so far as he could in the brief time at his disposal, to assist the fleet by digging wells, and by doing what could be done to provide markets and shelter for the fleet.

- How does Arrian (Source 1) explain why Alexander disbanded his fleet?
- According to Plutarch (Source 2) and Arrian (Source 3), what problems were faced by Alexander and his men when they crossed the Gedrosian desert? How does Arrian explain why Alexander journeyed through the Gedrosian desert? Which source (2 or 3) makes the losses of men during the journey across the Gedrosian desert seem the worst? Why?
- Why might some modern historians say that the disbanding of the fleet and Alexander's march through the Gedrosian desert are examples of poor strategic judgment on his part? Do you agree?

The Alexander Sarcophagus from Sidon showing Alexander in action

